

SIPRA DAS



On Road to the Ballot Box

DELHI A mid-term poll is possibly every Lok Sabha MPs worst nightmare. When a smiling CPI(M)'s Mohammad Salim walked into the lower House last week, he was asked, "Have you switched over to the Rajya Sabha? Why are you smiling so much?"

Faced with the very real prospect of their worst fears being realised, it was a chaotic monsoon session of Parliament that adjourned sine die on September 10 as each party shifted into pre-poll posturing. Scared that the

Left would portray this as anti-Muslim by pushing a pro-US stance, the UPA Government quickly tabled the Action Taken Report on the Sachar Committee findings while the communists raised the issue of price hike along with the nuke deal.

Meanwhile, Sharad Pawar has advised his daughter and the rest of his party MPs to start preparing for polls while Lalu Yadav, a Rajya Sabha member, told his cabinet colleagues to visit their constituencies more often.

SHAKY GROUND: MPs worry about mid-term polls
BJP has also prepared a laundry list of issues such as price hike and terrorism, which could be raised at the ground level.

It's not just about the right issues—quick-fix is also being liberally applied to shaky alliances. Recently, party stalwart L.K. Advani hosted a working lunch in the Capital that actually worked as he hastily smoothed out differences with the Shiv Sena.

But the born-again Third Front hasn't been so lucky. There seems to be trouble in paradise with Amar Singh and Jayalalithaa having connectivity problems. And a glum Congress is realising that if not the Left then its next government may have to depend on an imperious Mayawati. According to some party MPs, the first thing that Mayawati would demand would be a statue of Kanshi Ram and is even scouting for a location. That's called being prepared for any eventuality. And that sums up the current mood of the 14th Lok Sabha. **by Priya Sahgal**

SIGNPOSTS

WON: The Asia Cup by the **Indian hockey team**, which beat South Korea 7-2 in Chennai.

ARRESTED: Ex-Punjab DGP and Padmashree awardee **S. S. Virk**, on charges of possessing assets disproportionate to his known income, misuse of his official position and harbouring former terrorists.

CONFERRED: On pace bowler **Jhulan Goswami**, 23, the ICC's Woman Cricketer of the Year award.



GRANTED: By the Supreme Court, bail to Memon's **Yusuf Razak, Rubina, Essa** and **Mubina**, convicted in the 1993 Mumbai blasts case, on the ground that they have not yet received a copy of the judgement.

AWARDED: To **Dr K. Ullas Karanth**, the J. Paul Getty Award for Conservation Leadership by the World Wildlife Fund.

VIS-A-VIS **J. JAYALALITHAA** AIADMK chief **versus** **AMAR SINGH** Samajwadi Party general secretary

Some developments make me wonder if the AIADMK is still a part of UNPA or whether the UNPA continues to exist as one entity at all.



SAURABH SINGH



The UNPA is intact, the AIADMK is very much a part of it. But no one can try to control or curb activities of the Samajwadi Party.

EPILOGUE: United National Progressive Alliance doesn't seem to believe in putting up a united front.